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Lecture 4: Systems of Government

Political Science — Master Notes · by Jakob V. Stangel

Required reading: OD ch. 5 (*Governing Institutions in Democracies*)

Theme of the lecture: the various elements of states and systems of government — the different types of executive and legislative systems, focusing in particular on parliamentarism vs. presidentialism.

Lecture frame (FK). *Why it matters:* the institutional set-up shapes policy with big downstream consequences for people and businesses, and explains why democracies function so differently (US flashpoints the lecture cites: **Citizens United**, **Roe v. Wade**, the **filibuster**). Everything below runs on Lijphart's **majoritarian ↔ consensus** framing + Tsebelis's **veto players**.

OD Ch. 5 — Governing Institutions in Democracies

Book: Orvis & Drogus, *Introducing Comparative Politics*, 5th ed., ch. 5.

Chapter résumé

How democracies organise their governing institutions — **executive, legislature, judiciary, bureaucracy**, and the **national ↔ subnational** split — and why the same rules on paper produce different outcomes depending on **context** (party number/discipline, institutionalisation). The organising claim: **the executive–legislative relationship "more than anything else distinguishes different kinds of democracies,"** giving three models — **parliamentarism** (fusion, Westminster), **presidentialism** (separation, US), and **semi-presidentialism** (dual executive, France/Russia) — judged on **accountability, effective policymaking, and stability**. It sits all this on Lijphart's **majoritarian ↔ consensus** continuum (few vs many **veto players**), then covers judicial review, bureaucracy (the principal–agent problem), and **federal vs unitary** systems.

★ **The heart of the chapter:** the **executive–legislative relationship** is what most distinguishes democracies — **parliamentary** (powers *fused*), **presidential** (powers *separated*), or **semi-presidential** (executive *split*). Each is a different answer to **how executive power is chosen, checked, and removed** — trading off **accountability, effective policymaking and stability**.

The red thread. Everything hangs on one question: **how is executive power organised and held accountable?** Place each system on Lijphart's **majoritarian ↔ consensus** line (few ↔ many **veto players**): Westminster parliamentarism = most majoritarian (power concentrated, clear vertical accountability, weak horizontal check); US presidentialism = built-in separation/veto players (strong

horizontal check, gridlock-prone). For any case ask: **how is the executive chosen** • **how is it removed** • **how many veto players** • **what's the accountability/efficiency/stability trade-off?**

Key concepts / "modes" to use

- **Executive** split into **head of state** (symbolic, represents the country) vs **head of government** (runs policy).
- **The three systems:** **parliamentary** (fusion) • **presidential** (separation) • **semi-presidential** (split executive).
- **Majoritarian** ↔ **consensus democracy** (Lijphart) + **veto players** (Tsebelis) — the master frame.
- **Vertical vs horizontal accountability** (O'Donnell) — citizens→state vs state→state.
- **Judicial review** (+ common vs code law) • **principal-agent problem** (bureaucracy) • **federal vs unitary**.
- **The stability debate:** Linz's "*Perils of Presidentialism*."

Section-by-section main points

| The framing — majoritarian vs consensus, and accountability

Core: institutions differ by **how much they concentrate vs disperse power** — Lijphart's majoritarian↔consensus line, measured by the number of **veto players**.

- **Majoritarian** (UK): single-party executive, executive dominates the legislature, unicameral, easily amended constitution → **few veto players**. **Consensus** (US/Germany): coalition executives, executive-legislative balance, bicameral, rigid constitution → **many veto players**.
- **Veto player** (Tsebelis): any actor whose agreement is needed to change policy — more of them (+ greater ideological distance) = less policy change.
- **Accountability** (O'Donnell): **vertical** = citizens hold the state accountable (elections, ch. 6); **horizontal** = state institutions check each other (this chapter). Only the **executive** is essential to all states; legislature + judiciary exist to *limit* it.

★ **Why the majoritarian/PR choice matters for redistribution** (Iversen & Soskice 2006 — from the deck): with three classes (lower/middle/upper), in a **proportional** system the **middle class sides with the lower class** to redistribute from the rich → **bigger welfare states**; in a **majoritarian** system the middle class sides with the **upper class** to avoid heavy taxes from the poor → **less redistribution**. This is a big reason PR democracies redistribute more — a bridge to Lecture 5, and it helps explain the Sweden vs US welfare puzzle.

| Executives & legislatures

Core: the executive fills two roles — **head of state** (symbolic) and **head of government** (policy) — and *how those relate to the legislature* defines the three systems.

- One person can hold both roles (US president) or they can be split (UK monarch + PM). The **executive-legislative relationship** is the key variable.

- **Legislatures: unicameral** (one house) vs **bicameral** (two — the upper house usually represents states/regions; standard in federal systems). Legislatures are *more powerful in presidential systems* (members aren't chasing cabinet seats, so they stay independent) than in parliamentary ones.

Parliamentarism — the Westminster model (*most emphasised*)

Core: executive and legislature are **fused** — parliament elects the chief executive (**PM**), who is *both* the majority-party leader *and* a sitting legislator. The purest **majoritarian** form.

- **PM is not directly elected:** citizens vote for parliament; the majority names the PM (in practice you know each party's candidate). A **ceremonial head of state** (monarch, or an esteemed elected "president") stays out of politics.
- **Removal = vote of no confidence** → PM resigns (party picks a new leader) *or* asks the head of state to call **new elections**; PM can also **dissolve** parliament. Usually **no fixed terms**. (No-confidence votes succeed only ~5% of the time but signal weakness.)
- **Power depends on the party system:** a disciplined single majority makes the PM "*the most powerful democratic executive in the world*" (legislation passes almost automatically). **No majority → coalition government**, small parties become **veto players**, stability drops (Sweden 2018: 133 days to form a government).
- **Cabinet** of ministers (must be MPs); in coalitions the PM must share out "portfolios" — the cabinet is the main policy-bargaining site and a check on the PM.

Presidentialism — the separation of powers

Core: executive and legislature are **elected separately with separate powers** (separation of powers, Montesquieu). The defining feature is *separation*, not that one person is both head of state & government.

- **President is directly elected** and serves a **fixed term**; branches generally **can't remove each other** (only a hard **impeachment**). This builds in **institutional veto players** — lawmaking needs *both* president and legislative majority → checks & balances, but **gridlock** (esp. under divided government).
- **Cabinet** is freely appointed (often non-legislators, any party), subject to legislative consent — but it's a **less important** body than in parliamentary systems. The **legislature is typically more powerful** than in parliamentary systems.
- **Coalitional presidentialism:** with fragmented legislatures the president must build an informal party coalition and act "a little like a PM" (**Brazil** is the classic case).

Semi-presidentialism — the hybrid

Core: executive power is **split** between a **directly elected president** (head of state, with real powers) and a **PM** (head of government, backed by the parliamentary majority, appointed by the president, removable by no-confidence).

- Legislation needs the president's signature **and** PM/majority support; the powers must be **clearly divided** (often unclear in practice). Originated in **France, 1958 (de Gaulle)**.
- **Cohabitation:** president and legislative majority from **different parties** → president appoints an opposing-party PM (French norm: president runs foreign policy, PM runs domestic). Limits

presidential power but can cause gridlock.

- **Elgie's key question:** *can the president dismiss the PM?* If **yes** → unstable, democracy endangered (**Russia**); if **no** → more power-sharing, no less stable than parliamentarism.

★ The core comparison — parliamentary vs presidential vs semi-presidential

Core: learn this table cold — it's the centre of the lecture and the exam.

Feature	Parliamentary	Presidential	Semi-presidential
Powers	Fused (exec from legislature)	Separated (elected independently)	Split executive (pres + PM)
Head of state / govt	Separate (monarch/ceremonial pres + PM)	Same person (president)	President (HoS, real powers) + PM (HoG)
Executive chosen by	Parliament (majority names PM)	Directly elected	President directly elected; PM by parliament
Terms	Usually no fixed term	Fixed term	Fixed presidential term; PM depends on parliament
How executive is removed	<u>Vote of no confidence</u> (+ PM can dissolve parliament)	Only impeachment (hard)	PM by no-confidence; president fixed
Veto players	Few (majoritarian)	Built-in (pres + legislature)	Depends (cohabitation adds them)
Classic cases	UK, Germany, India	USA, Brazil	France, Russia

- **Accountability:** parliamentarism = clearest **vertical** (voters know whom to blame) but weak **horizontal** under a single majority; presidentialism = strong **horizontal** (separation) but can hurt policymaking.
- **Policymaking (Samuels):** presidential systems **change the status quo less** and more slowly.
Illustration: Thatcher (UK) reshaped economic policy far more than Reagan (US) despite similar aims — she had a compliant majority; he faced a Democratic Congress.

The stability debate — Linz's "Perils of Presidentialism"

Core: Linz (1990): presidentialism is more crisis-prone because of three flaws; but critics say the *society*, not the institution, is the real problem.

- **Linz's three perils:** ① **dual legitimacy** (two independently elected branches, no democratic tie-breaker) • ② **winner-take-all** presidents over-read their mandate and won't compromise • ③ **inflexible fixed terms** (a failing president can't be removed). Danger peaks for *new democracies* under **coalitional presidentialism** (small presidential party + fragmented legislature).
- **Counter (Cheibub 2007):** presidential systems just "*tend to exist in societies where democracies of any type are likely to be unstable.*" Semi-presidentialism is empirically **no less stable than parliamentarism** — if the president can't override the legislature or sack the PM.

Judiciary

Core: courts interpret law and, via judicial review, can strike laws as unconstitutional — making them a veto player and a check on the majority (the "why should unelected judges decide?" problem). Only real if institutionalised.

- **Two legal families:** **common law** (precedent; UK/US → *decentralised, concrete* review) vs **code law** (written-only, Napoleon; French/Iberian colonies → *centralised, abstract* review via a special constitutional court).
- "**Judicialisation of politics**" (Tate & Vallinder) — a major recent trend. Judicial **independence** rests largely on **informal** factors (a fragmented, competitive political system gives courts room) and on hard-won **legitimacy** (courts have no army/purse).

Bureaucracy

Core: every state needs a merit-based, law-bound bureaucracy — but unelected officials with expertise create a principal-agent problem (agents pursue their own interests → inefficiency or corruption).

- Controls: **political appointees**, specific legislation, **legislative oversight**, courts — none perfect. New Public Management (NPM) (Reagan/Thatcher, 1980s): privatise, add competition, "customer satisfaction," flatten hierarchies — a UK 30-year study found a 1/3 staff cut but slightly *higher* costs and slightly *worse* service.
- **Corruption: bribery + rent-seeking**; worse in more-regulated, more-unequal economies. **Majoritarian** systems (clear responsibility) let voters punish it better. Johnston's four syndromes: *Influence Markets* (rich democracies) → *Elite Cartels* → *Oligarchs & Clans* → *Official Moguls* (poorest).

Federal vs unitary systems

Core: **unitary** = the centre holds sole sovereignty (local powers delegated & revocable); **federal** = sovereignty is **constitutionally shared** with subunits — a built-in way to **limit majorities and protect minorities** (more veto players).

- **Why federate:** bring government closer (big countries); divide power (bicameral upper house + judicial review); protect ethnic/religious minorities (**Belgium** = federalism + consociationalism; **541 days** to form a government in 2010).
- Real power depends on **revenue control** and **upper-house strength**, not paper rules (strong **US Senate** vs weak German **Bundesrat**). **Symmetrical** (US) vs **asymmetrical** (special powers for some units). **Devolution** = reversible decentralisation in a unitary state (UK → Scotland/Wales/N. Ireland). Riker: federalism is inherently unstable (→ centralisation or secession).
- *Examples:* **federal** = US, Germany; **unitary** = France, UK, **Denmark**. In US federalism the **national** level holds war & foreign policy, coining money, admitting new states; **states** hold schools, public welfare, local law & order (the "**Hamilton** [federal] vs **Jefferson** [states]" division).

Cases & examples

Why these cases are here — circle them back. Each country shows **one system in practice** — and how the *same rules* give different results depending on the **party system**. Read each for: *which system · how power actually flows · the accountability/stability trade-off*.

Case	System	What it adds
UK	Parliamentary (Westminster)	strongest PM — until Brexit broke party discipline
India	Parliamentary	same rules, different outcome via the party system
USA	Presidential	<u>separation of powers</u> → gridlock; strongest legislature
Brazil	Coalitional presidentialism	strong formal powers ≠ effective power (30 parties)
Russia	Semi-presidential	dominant president → electoral authoritarianism
Japan	(bureaucracy)	unelected bureaucratic power (iron triangles, <i>amakudari</i>)

- **United Kingdom — Westminster parliamentarism.** With a disciplined single majority, the PM is "the most powerful democratic executive in the world." But **Brexit** shattered discipline: May's deal was crushed, parliament seized the agenda, 117 of her own MPs voted no-confidence, she resigned — and **Boris Johnson became PM via a ~160,000-member party vote, no national election.** → *Parliamentarism; the majority-party mechanism (not paper rules) drives PM power; removal via no-confidence + party replacement.*
- **India — same model, different result.** India copied Westminster almost exactly, yet outcomes track its **party system**: one-party (Congress) dominance 1947–89 made PMs *less* constrained than British ones; post-1989 **coalitions** forced constant negotiation (3 PMs in the first 30 years → 12 in the next 30). → *Identical rules → different outcomes based on party number; multipartism pushes parliamentarism toward consensus.*
- **United States — presidential separation of powers.** The Framers feared a strong executive, so the president's *formal* powers are modest (veto, appointments with Senate consent, commander-in-chief); **separation of powers + weak, polarised parties → gridlock**, the norm under divided government (Senate 60-vote rule). Contested workarounds: signing statements, executive orders. → *Presidentialism; built-in veto players; the world's most powerful legislature (Congress).*
- **Brazil — coalitional presidentialism.** The 1988 constitution gives the president **more** formal power than the US president (decrees, line-item veto, budget monopoly) — yet **~30 fragmented parties** (Bolsonaro's own held <10% of seats) force presidents to build **9-party coalitions**, trade pork for votes (often illegally), and still face impeachment (**Dilma Rousseff, 2016**). → *Strong formal powers ≠ effective power; the instability Linz warned of.*
- **Russia — semi-presidentialism gone dominant.** The 1993 constitution created an exceptionally strong presidency (appoints PM — reject the nominee 3× and the Duma is dissolved; **decrees with force of law**). **Putin** used it to turn a weak democracy into an **electoral authoritarian regime**. → *Elgie's warning: a president who can dismiss the PM at will removes the incentive to compromise and endangers democracy.*
- **Japan — bureaucratic power.** Japan's elite bureaucracy (recruited from Tokyo University law) drove the postwar boom and often *wrote* the laws, via **iron triangles** (bureaucrats–politicians–business) and ***amakudari*** ("descent from heaven" — officials taking jobs in firms they'd regulated). Scandals + stagnation eroded it; Abe's 2014 reform tripled PM appointment control. → *The principal-agent problem: unelected officials wielding real power.*

Key terms

Term	Meaning
Executive / Legislature / Judiciary	Implements / makes / interprets the law
Head of state / Head of government	Symbolic representative / runs the government
Majoritarian / Consensus democracy	Power concentrated (few veto players) / dispersed (many)
Veto player	Actor whose agreement is needed to change policy
Vertical / Horizontal accountability	Citizens hold state accountable / institutions check each other
Parliamentarism	Exec & legislature fused; parliament elects the PM
Vote of no confidence	Parliament's vote to remove the PM/government
Presidentialism	Exec & legislature elected independently, separate powers
Separation of powers	Constitutional division of power among branches
Coalitional presidentialism	Presidential system where the president must build a party coalition
Semi-presidentialism	Executive split between elected president + PM
Cohabitation	President & PM from different parties
Judicial review	Courts can rule a law unconstitutional
Common law / Code law	Precedent-based / written-code-only
Principal-agent problem	Agent's self-interest may not match the principal's
New Public Management	1980s reform: privatise, competition, "customer" focus
Unitary / Federal	Sole central sovereignty / sovereignty shared with subunits
Symmetrical / Asymmetrical federalism	All subunits equal / some have special powers
Devolution	Reversible decentralisation in a unitary state

Exam pointers

- Reproduce the parliamentary vs presidential vs semi-presidential comparison cold — powers (fused/separated/split), how the executive is **chosen** and **removed**, term length, veto players, a case each.
- Explain parliamentarism (fusion, PM, no-confidence, dissolution) and presidentialism (separation, fixed terms, impeachment, gridlock) as opposite answers to *how executive power is checked*.
- Use Lijphart's **majoritarian ↔ consensus** + **veto players** to place any system, and **vertical vs horizontal accountability** to evaluate it.
- Deploy Linz's "Perils of Presidentialism" (dual legitimacy · winner-take-all · fixed terms) *and* the Cheibub counter — the set-piece stability debate.

- Show that **rules** $\neq$ **outcomes**: UK vs India (party system) and Thatcher vs Reagan (policymaking) are the go-to illustrations.
- Know **federal vs unitary** (+ devolution) as a majority-limiting / minority-protecting device.

★ Fun facts & memorable details

Sticky stats, dates & quotes from Lecture 4 (systems of government).

Quotable / memorable

- Linz's famous article: "**The Perils of Presidentialism**" (1990). Cheibub's rebuttal: presidential systems "*tend to exist in societies where democracies of any type are likely to be unstable.*"
- The British PM with a solid majority is "*often called the most powerful democratic executive in the world.*"
- **Kenya (2013)** switched from a British-style **parliamentary** to a US-style **presidential** system with its new constitution — a live natural experiment.

Striking numbers

- **Belgium 2010**: a world-record **541 days** to form a government; **Sweden 2018**: 133 days.
- Votes of no confidence **succeed ~5% of the time**.
- **Boris Johnson** became PM chosen by **fewer than 160,000** Conservative members — no national election.
- **India**: 3 PMs in 1947–77 → **12** in 1977–2007 (multipartism = less stability).
- **Brazil**: 30 parties in the Chamber; presidential coalitions average **9 parties**; **60% of Congress under indictment** in 2016.
- **US Senate**: representatives of just over **10%** of the population can block a bill (60-vote rule); state representation ratio $\approx$ **66:1**.
- **Semi-presidentialism** spread from **10 (1990)** → **52 (2018)** systems; 16 are former French/Portuguese colonies.
- **Federal** countries $\approx$ **25**, but hold **>40% of the world's population**; 7 of the 10 largest countries by area are federal.

Thinkers to name-drop

- Separation of powers ← **Montesquieu** · semi-presidentialism ← **France 1958 / de Gaulle** · code law ← **Napoleon** · majoritarian/consensus ← **Lijphart** · veto players ← **Tsebelis** · vertical/horizontal accountability ← **O'Donnell** · federalism-as-bargain ← **Riker**.
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